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Earl May

Bassist Earl May was born in New York City on September 17, 1927. He spent eight productive years in the 50s with the Billy Taylor Trio and was the bassist on John Coltrane's album "Lush Life." Earl's ability to play a wide variety of styles has enabled him to share the stage and studio with a lengthy list of jazz luminaries.

Earl was interviewed in New York City on January 11, 2001, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we are in New York City filming for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive. I'm very pleased to have Earl May with me today. You know you have a lot of people who say nice things about you, did you know that?

EM: Really? No I didn't know that.

MR: Yes, you do.

EM: It's so nice to hear that.

MR: Yeah. Jane Jarvis—

EM: Oh that's my sweetheart.

MR: And Eddie Locke and so forth.

EM: Oh yeah.

MR: So they seem to like your playing as well as you as a person.

EM: That's doubly nice to hear that.

MR: You've been in New York all your life?

EM: All my life. I was born and raised in New York. I've been living in New Jersey now for the last twenty-five years or so.

MR: What led you into thinking that music could be a career. Because I know that you didn't quite start out as a musician, did you?

EM: I've always had a thought about playing music. Always. Even when I was a little kid. Because this is sort of personal, but my mother and father really didn't get along too well. So I was probably — it's not probably, I did — I stayed with every relative, aunt and uncle and cousin and you know like that, that was in this neighborhood. So I was staying with my aunt, and my cousin who was going to school at that time — we're talking about when I was three or four years old — I would be in the house by myself. I'm going crazy and driving her nuts. She would send me down to the basement. There was an old victrola, a wind-up, and it was, "Go down there and play any records." So I fell in over this tune, a record, I never knew who it was, but it was "China Boy" [scats]. And I wanted to play the guitar, because that was the predominant instrument on that record.

And when my mother came out to visit and she told me that my cousin, who was two years older than I was, is going to study the piano and she wanted to know what instrument I wanted to play, I said I don't know what it's called but I knew it had strings. You know, I'm thinking about the guitar. She gives me the violin. So I wound up studying the violin until I was about nine years old. And I hated it. But I've always had dreams from that record, of going in the basement, I've always had dreams of being on the stage and playing in a jazz band. That's what I always wanted to do, ever since I was a little kid.

MR: Who do you suppose that was? Like Eddie Condon?

EM: Oh I have no idea who that was. I have not a clue.

MR: A lot of people did that tune I know.

EM: Yeah, yeah.

MR: So it could have been any number—

EM: It's hard to say, and even if I heard it now I don't know if I would, you know. But my mother says that when she was carrying me she would go up to the Apollo once a week, so she thinks that's where it all started. I don't know whether that's true or not but it could be.

MR: It makes for a good story. You were absorbing it. But you found the bass eventually.

EM: Yeah that was by accident also. Because I always felt that I could see myself up there like a Buddy Rich or a Gene Krupa or some great drummer, with the spotlight on him you know, and all the girls looking at you you know, and that'd be great. So I would take my little allowance you know and go down on 42nd Street, and a Wurlitzer, and take drum lessons on Saturday. And when I got to high school I was going to study the drums. But when I got there — oh Sonny Payne was in that school at that time, and he was like the big, big thing at the Ben Franklin, where a lot of guys went to, like oh there was bunch of us that went there: Sonny Rollins, Jackie McLean. And when I got to the drum class it was so crowded he had students in the hallway. So he says, "Why don't you go in the bass class?" he grabbed me by my ear. So Walter Bishop was in that class for some reason. It was just the two of us. And he told me — that was when I first met him, too — and he said to me after ten minutes or so of just being in the class waiting for the teacher to come, so he said to me, "Well I don't know, you got it kid, I'm not going to be in this class." I was the only one in the bass class. And naturally being left handed, when we had ensemble, you know playing with the orchestra you know, I would play right handed. And when he wouldn't look I would play left handed. Then he would stop the band — "get on the other side." So it took me a while before I decided, well I don't know what side to stand on, I'm more comfortable playing left handed, but I'd never heard of a left handed bass player. But I decided to just stay and make myself comfortable. Because I

had no idea that I would have any kind of career like I've had you know. I played with Charlie Parker and Billy Taylor and Miles Davis' band and I've had all kinds of great, wonderful experiences you know, Dizzy Gillespie and all that stuff. So had I thought I probably would have —

MR: Made yourself stay in the band.

EM: Made myself play in there. Because I sort of defeated myself in a little way. Because there's a lot of things that right handed players can do, I can't do. Some things. Some technical things. And it would look kind of strange for me to be in a classical orchestra, and everybody else is going this way, it kind of didn't make much sense.

MR: Did you think about re-stringing the bass?

EM: I did. I tried that for a while. But then I said, I was playing with Billy Taylor's trio at the time. And I remember one Saturday in New York, it was like New Year's Eve every night. The streets were crowded, the cars were bumper to bumper and you couldn't get anywhere. And I remember us having to go — in between sets — we'd have to go into a studio and say for instance do a quick television thing and go back to the club.

MR: In between sets?

EM: In between sets, yes. And so in those days it was very difficult to get around. So I says I'm not going to have to wait for another cab or something like that, I wanted to just get in the cab with the trio and go over and play whatever bass is there. But if I have to have a special bass, I'm really defeating my whole thing. So I said I'll play a right handed bass left handed. So that's what I decided.

MR: That's interesting that such a — it becomes a practical decision you know, to make this gig and do what I have to do, I can't afford to change the strings on my bass.

EM: Right. And you don't have time to go in there and rearrange everything. It would be terrible.

MR: This was about what — you played with Billy Taylor most of the 50s, right?

EM: In the early 50s. I started with him around 1951 I think.

MR: So there was a pretty healthy recording and live music scene at that time.

EM: Oh yeah, oh wonderful. You know when people ask me now to go back in your life and pick out a time that you really, the time that you most enjoyed, and I would have to say the time I spent with Billy. Because not only was it a good trio and playing good music and all like that, it was a real brotherly kind of thing that we had, Billy and I had, and also I was playing — when Billy wasn't working — I was playing up at Minton's with all kinds of wonderful people, Carmen McRae and Tony Scott and playing with all these wonderful people. And I recorded with Trane during that time, and played with Miles Davis' band and I played with Charlie Parker's band. So it was a wonderful time for me.

MR: In retrospect, when you think about playing with Coltrane and Miles and Charlie Parker, is there things that stick out in you mind that maybe at the time didn't make an impression on you but in later years? That's an awful big question.

EM: It is. Let's see if I can break it down. I hope I can answer your question. You know when you're going through these things, let's say, what I get from your question is when you're going through these things it's not like another gig because I was scared to death. I was really scared. But when you look back now, or even I can really see the magnitude, if there is such a word, of what I had done, you know being in those bands and playing with those great, great people. I mean if I could have done that now, I just wish I could, you know, what I know now, even though I felt, and Charles McPherson and I talk about this quite a bit. And it seems that the older you get you don't really have — you lose some things and you gain some things. So you have the knowledge but for some reason or another I'm having more trouble now with the beat. You know when I was younger, I can hear some of the recordings I made and it was very, very natural for me to stand up there and just never, I mean my time was just like a metronome. I mean that's one of the nice things I could say about myself. I had really good time. I was probably noted for that. But now it seems to me I'm having so much trouble just trying to keep that thing steady. And I can't figure out what it is.

MR: Is it a physical—

EM: I don't know.

MR: I mean playing the bass is pretty physical.

EM: It is. Yeah it is. But I really can't figure out what it is. Charles McPherson and I talk about it like I said before. But he thinks that, you know I'm not mentioning any names, but when you start listening to people that are around my age, we listen to records that they made thirty years ago, forty years ago, and the way they play now, and you play with them live, it's a little different. Everybody seems to not be in the pocket like as easily as it used to be.

MR: From a business and economic standpoint, was it a decent living for you in those years, in the 50s?

EM: Oh yeah. I'll tell you why, because not being trained at all, not playing the bass left handed like that, I couldn't study formally or anything like that. So I just wound up saying to myself I'm going to have a day job during the week, I don't know, five days a week or whatever, and I'll work on the weekends just playing weddings and bar mitzvahs and things like that. And then actually Billy Taylor was the one that made the decision for me, because I'm thinking that I'm just married and I've got a young baby you know and I want to be a good provider you know. And Billy asked me to open Birdland with him and make all these gigs, and be a steady member of his trio, and I'm saying well I

don't know, I don't know. I don't want to have to scuffle. And finally I just took a chance. My wife game me an opportunity. She said well you just follow your mind. I'm very happy I did that because on the weekends I would make three times the money I would make on my day job, working for an insurance company at that time and playing, like I said, playing with all these other people. So financially it was really very good. But my wife at that time told me that I was too giving. I'm always giving my money away and buying people drinks and—

MR: Really?

EM: Oh man, big sporty orty here. Really. Oh I've got a live one.

MR: Are you still that way?

EM: I'm still that way. I just made a record date with Jane [Jarvis] and Benny and Grady. [Tate]. And at the end of the date she treated us financially very well. So I put the check in my pocket and I told Benny I said, "Ah, Benny, I've got some money, I can start tipping again." He fell on the floor. Because I do that a lot. I feel that that's what it's for, to share a little bit. People are working and giving you a service, you treat them nice. So I went right down to the garage and took my car, I gave that guy a six dollar tip.

MR: Well now I know why everybody says nice things about you.

EM: Yeah, I don't know what it is.

MR: You played on "Lush Life" with Coltrane?

EM: Um hum. Scared to death.

MR: This was fairly early in his career, right?

EM: Yeah, it was 1957 I think it was.

MR: Did you have a sense that he was going to be a major innovator?

EM: Oh yeah, sure. I'll tell you why. Because if I'd go and hear Miles, I remember the first time I heard Trane. I went to — Miles was advertised someplace on the east side. There was, it was in the 70s or something like that, there was a jazz club over there. And I went over to see him. I sat down at a table and listen to him play. And he came off the bandstand while everybody was playing, and he crouched beside me at the table and we were talking. And he was saying, "Wait 'till you hear this tenor player." He says to me, "This guys plays more notes than anybody I ever heard in my life." He says, "Good thing I don't have to pay him by the amount of notes he plays." And so I listened and I was very impressed. I think Bill Evans was in that band.

MR: Right. This, wow — they made some great records too.

EM: Yeah, they sure did. So when Trane asked me to play on a record date with him, to make a record date, boy I was—

MR: Now would you get together and rehearse for something like that?

EM: No, that was right in the studio.

MR: Just come and—

EM: He'd ask me, "You know this tune?" And he said, "Well we're going to do like, I want you to play this kind of an intro" [scats]. He would just tell me what he wanted and I would do my best. But I was so scared. I was so scared. That date, the takes that came out, not very favorable in my direction because Arthur Taylor was way — like almost in the other room. We did it at Rudy VanGelder's, in his living room at that time you know. And he really separated us. So I didn't really lock up with the drummer like I really wanted to. And Red Garland called halfway through the date and said that his car broke down so he wouldn't make the date, so we wound up doing the whole thing as a trio, which was another frightening thing for me.

MR: Wow.

EM: But I've heard some other takes from that same session where I played much better than the one that came out. As a matter of fact I have a copy at home.

MR: Oh that's nice.

EM: But I shudder when people tell me — we talk about that date — because it wasn't a very, completely happy experience for me, because of what I failed to do as far as the beat was concerned. You can go back to that again.

MR: Wow. Do you suppose you are your own worst critic?

EM: Oh I know that. I know that. I know I am.

MR: I see that you spent a little bit of time early on with Charles Mingus?

EM: Yeah I did. Yeah. He was nice enough to teach me, give me some formal training. I love him for that. I still try to give all that knowledge away to young people. I sit back and I say, "Listen, you come to my house and I'll show you exactly what he told me and how to do it" and all like that. Percy Heath was a student of his also. He was nice enough to teach about a handful of us. A handful. Wonderful technique.

MR: He must have had like different ends of his personality.

EM: I got along with him extremely well. He would come to my house, have dinner, he and his wife, and after dinner he and I would go in the bedroom and play duets. He was really wonderful to me. Really, really nice. He scared the life out of me once though. I mean he really shook me up. 'Cause he was saying like, "Now when you have a thing like where you're going to play F seventh to a B flat" — whatever chord — "this is how you would do it." And I didn't quite understand, so I said, "Well how would you" I mean I wanted him to demonstrate, you know like say if you were playing in the tune, and that's what I thought he was going to say. But he said, "What do you mean? You think I'm giving you stuff you're not going to use?" Really threw me for a loop. But that's the only time I ever had any kind of run in with him, that he really shook me up, he scared me to death. But I

think I'd have to say, because he always showed me that I was kind of a favorite of his. He was very proud of me, he'd tell people, "Yeah, that's my student."

MR: Did a lot of your work come from recommendations like that?

EM: From Mingus you mean?

MR: From Mingus or other players?

EM: I'm trying to think about that. I think what happens, which happens today, is that people kind of know what you're capable of. And they'll call you if they think that you can fit the bill. I think that's basically what happens you know.

MR: Yeah. Let's see, Herbie Mann and Dizzy and Joe Newman, I mean you've played with just about everybody, right?

EM: Yeah, I had a wonderful time. I had a lot of wonderful gigs and some of my favorite gigs were with Joe Newman say for instance, very exciting, with Ted Dunbar playing guitar you know, Frank Foster. I'm still playing with Frank, he's one of my all time favorites. A great writer, great player, great person to be with, be on the road with. And just a real homey kind of, very warm, wonderful person.

MR: How much road work was involved in your—

EM: In my career?

MR: In your career?

EM: Well you'd have to ask — I've been married four times. You'd have to ask my other three wives.

MR: Okay, well—

EM: I think what happens is that they think it's kind of a nice life, and they want to be with me, but I'm not there. On weekends I'm not home, on holidays I'm not home. So it gets kind of really — I come in at night, "Earl is that you?" Like it's kind of frightening you know. But we're all good friends, I mean all my ex-wives call the house everyday. As a matter of fact this week alone I've spoken to, well everybody, all my ex-wives. They all call my house. My wife is good friends with everybody. They say, "Is he still doing—" something. "Yeah, yeah, yeah."

MR: Did they ever try going with you?

EM: Not the others like as much as my present wife. She just goes, "Yeah, come on, let's go." And she jumps right on it. She rearranges her work schedule so that she can be with me. We just went to Paris the latter part of last year. Had a wonderful time. It was just like being on a honeymoon. Because I really miss that. I mean it's wonderful to share some of the things that I've gone through with someone that you really love. It's wonderful. I just get tickled every time I think about that.

MR: Cool. The reception you get overseas, I've heard it's pretty good for jazz musicians when they go overseas.

EM: It is. I love — they seem to know more about my career, what I've done, things that I've forgotten about. Even in Japan it's like that. I'm sorry to say it's not like that here. But it seems as though — maybe it's just this period we're going through with all this, with the film going on on Channel 13 and that whole series and the IMJK—

MR: Right, whatever this thing in that's going on here. The thousands of people.

EM: And meeting you and all.

MR: How do you feel about the — I'm not sure how to ask this question, but does the interest and the educational component that's going on, does it filter down for the musicians in work?

EM: Yes. I think so.

MR: I'm glad to hear that.

EM: Yeah. It might not last too long. It's just like when the festivals come in town. It seems like everybody's working. All the little joints in town, they have some, they're a part of it. And then it kind of dies down for a while. Actually, I think jazz musicians work according to the economy. I mean it's just that wide a thing. We're the first ones to be put out of work when the things start getting a little tight.

MR: Yeah. People stop going out as much?

EM: Yeah, right, exactly.

MR: It seems like it's an expensive proposition to go out and hear jazz sometimes.

EM: It is. It's very expensive. If you don't put a hundred bucks in your pocket, you might not have enough, to take your wife out, just to go to the club, not to have dinner and all that. So it's pretty expensive. And I remember Pearl Bailey told — I used to fill in for Milt Hinton when Milt couldn't make a gig or something like that I would go to Jordan's say for instance with Pearl. She was so wonderful to be with. And she would say that it's a shame that jazz musicians are kind of pricing themselves out of the business. Where you would take Sonny Rollins as a member of Miles Davis' band, and then he would break away and start his own band. And she was saying that if musicians really sat down and thought about what they were doing, and kind of stuck together, and — but there are other things involved other than just the money part of it. You know, you really want to say what you want to say. And you probably can't say everything that you want to say in Miles' band. So you have to start your own band. So in a way she was right, and in a way she didn't quite make too much sense.

MR: Do you think that's the scene happening today? Do you think musicians are pricing themselves out?

EM: Oh yeah. Oh today?

MR: Sometimes I wonder, for instance, when you go to the Iridium for instance, and you end up spending sixty dollars, is the musician profiting from that? If so, great.

EM: You're trying to help to keep the club open you know. The price of real estate in New York is so horrendous. It's amazing that some of these clubs pay like twenty-five, thirty thousand a month rent or maybe more. Plus they have light bills on top of that and other things that go along with it. So everybody's trying to just stay a little above the water you know. So I think everybody's like I am. You just want to play man. You just want to play. I think that's the only thing I've ever wanted to do in my life. Play jazz. And I still feel that way. I mean the thing that makes me happy is if I have a gig, with anybody, even with this band that we have, the thing to me that's most important, being a leader, is for me to lay down some nice bass lines that everybody can play on, and if the band is happy and it flows into the audience, and the audience goes home happy, but you don't bastardize yourself. You don't give up your principles and stuff for that. You don't do cockamamie things like, whatever, but just be true to yourself. And so that's really what I'm about. Trying to be a good bass player. Trying to put a good foundation there.

MR: I've heard similar thoughts expressed from Milt Hinton actually.

EM: Oh well.

MR: What a marvelous man he was.

EM: Oh he really was. You know when I was with Billy in the 50s, he was playing with Louis Armstrong, and Billy and I were playing opposite them. And Milt got hung up at a record date. And as a kid, I started, I was playing, maybe I was about fourteen years old. And I shouldn't have been but I was playing in a trio in a nightclub in the Bronx. And Louis came in and spoke to me and told me how he thought I sounded, and said keep it up and you're doing fine and all like that. And he knew I was a bass player with Billy's trio years later. And that particular night when Milt wasn't there and they were without a bass player he sent word for me and asked me if I would fill in for him. And I was scared to death. And I don't know whether he got a sense of that or what it was, he said, "Tell him never mind, we'll just play without the bass." And it broke my heart. But Milt could play that kind of music, he played in Cab Calloway's band, he can play straight ahead stuff, and then Dick Katz brought a tape that he made up in Minton's on that same gig that I was playing with Tony Scott, and it was Dick Katz and Osie Johnson, who was a wonderful drummer. So when I couldn't make the gig, Milt played the gig. And they recorded, they made a tape of this see. And Milt was playing such modern and such things, it was so hip and everything, that it's just amazing how he could just go and play any kind of music and just be so solid and positive about everything he did. Just amazing. I'm very proud of that, that Dick Katz let me hear that. Really astounding.

MR: I notice you started playing some electric bass.

EM: I was kind of forced into that.

MR: Yeah? Not something that you wanted to do?

EM: If I could do it well, if I could please myself. The word on the grapevine was Bob Cranshaw and I had about the same kind of sound. I thought he had a really wonderful sound. He's a really excellent playing string bass or — but that's the only other compliment I ever got out of that. I don't have the technique for that. So I've got to satisfy myself let's say. I'd rather hear somebody else play that.

MR: Plus you'd be playing it left handed.

EM: Yeah, playing it upside down.

MR: You and Paul McCartney.

EM: He reverses his strings.

MR: Oh yeah.

EM: Which makes — that I would have probably done. Because it's easy to carry.

MR: Yeah, that's true. It's that practical thing again.

EM: Right, right, exactly.

MR: How did this — you did some things with Gloria Lynne was it?

EM: Yeah, yeah, yeah, yeah, yeah. That was a lot of fun too, because I had a lot to do with the music. When I say that I mean I don't write or anything, I don't have that kind of technique or anything, but I'd come up with some ideas every once in a while, you know, where I would say, "Hey, let's start this tune—" where the introduction would be a rim shot [sings] bop — I see your face before me. Little dumb things like that I mean they weren't dumb but we have a lot of fun though. It was wonderful.

MR: What period was this?

EM: This was late 50s, right after Billy Taylor. I stayed with Billy from '51 to about late '59, and then I started with Gloria right after that, late '59 into the 60s, up to about '64 maybe. I'm sorry it didn't last longer than that but it wasn't my fault. But we had Herman Foster and Russell Elefante. And the compliments we got was that it actually was like if you saw one you would see the other three of us. The four of us. The trio and her. And we were very close, very, very — like I say you wouldn't see one without the other four. And then people would come in, when you're starting to reach a little success, people come in from the woodwork and they say, "Ah, man, you don't need this person, he's not doing anything, he's pimping off you" or something like that. The piano player's blind, he can't see, and you don't need the drummer, he can't read music. You don't need any of them. Come on and go with me. I'm going to put you in rooms that have dollar bills painted all over the walls. And she went for it. You know.

MR: Oh yeah. She became quite the pop—

EM: It can happen. So that broke that up, which was kind of sad. Because we all had dreams of staying together as long as the Modern Jazz Quartet or Gladys Knight and the Pips, you know staying together for thirty-five, forty years or something like that.

MR: Right. How has the changes in pop and rock music affected what you've done over the years? Or has it?

EM: I don't think it's really affected me very much. But I mean I will have to say that I have a lot of respect for young people. There are some that come out of school and they really have a lot to say. And then there are others that come out of school, the majority, where it's sad to say but they all seem to sound alike. I can't distinguish — the piano players all sound the same, the bass players all sound the same, and it's sad in that way. But there are some that come out like I'm trying to start — help them by having one other professional, when I say professional, one other seasoned player in a group where we'd feature a saxophone player or a singer and when the rest of them will be young people. When we're doing like things in jazz clubs and things like that. So we're going to start that kind of thing. Because just to boost people. If I knew that you had a son that's twelve years old or something like that and was trying to play harmonica, I would ask you to please bring him in and come and sit in with us. Just trying to encourage the young people to play and be a part of jazz.

MR: Jane Jarvis says that you have this amazing ability to pick the right notes as the chords progress and it would depend on whether this is a passing chord. She just is amazed at your ability.

EM: I thank her for that. I think what that comes from is playing with Billy and Bud Powell and playing with a lot of other people that I've played with. It comes from, especially with Billy. Because Billy would play things just to really see if he could fool me, to see if I couldn't find the bass. Nine times out of ten I would find the right note in the chord. And he says that's something that you either have it or you don't. I don't know how true that is. But she — when I play with her, especially if we're in a concert setting and she and I are just going to play, I love that. Because I ask her not to think about me being there. I just want her to be as free as possible and play. And I'll find her. I love that. I really love being able to try to put the right thing with whatever somebody's doing. I really enjoy that. It's a lot of fun. And nine times out of ten it works so I feel good about that part of my playing.

MR: Well you've come a long way since the violin. You did some work with the "Sophisticated Lady" show.

EM: Oh yeah, that was another wonderful experience of mine, just being on Broadway with that band and playing all that good music with all those wonderful people on stage. It was wonderful. And then going on the road with them was so nice. I had a wonderful time with that. We bonded, and we'd get on the bus and slap and giggle and you know, it was wonderful. I really had a good time. I got in a lot of income tax trouble over that, I'm still suffering from it, but other than that it was a wonderful experience. Duke was absolutely

incredible. Really amazing. And there was a story going around where I don't remember who the players were but this guy had just joined the band and he was saying — he stopped the band at one time, I don't know if they were rehearsing for a show or what — and he says, "Duke, you got this saxophone player playing F and you got me playing F sharp." And Duke says, "Just play for me, just, please."

MR: There's a reason you're doing that. That's a good one. How's the musician's union been for you over the years?

EM: It's been kind of dormant really. But we have people in there like Bob Cranshaw and Jimmy Owens and people that are really and -- And at one time Benny Powell was in there really pushing them really to help, to bring jazz musicians up to par. So it looks, because I did a lot of things, I was in the Playboy Club for instance once for a while, playing with Kai Winding, then I had my own quartet there or a while. Because I just wanted to stay around town. It was a good place, to have a nice, steady jazz gig and you could go in and out. And they seemed to have put in all the benefits and stuff but they didn't, so I feel kind of cheated for all that time I put in there. So Bob is trying to work on that for me. Because you know, it's pension time now.

MR: Yeah. It's unfortunate that so many musicians don't end up with what they should. Does the music tend to keep you young do you think?

EM: Oh without a doubt. Without a doubt. You know because it's always in the front of my mind is that I'm going to get it right. I'm going to really, I'm going to be the great bass player I really want to be. The great musicians just go in there and make everybody feel great.

MR: Wow. So you're kind of a life long learner I would guess.

EM: Yeah. I think I'd do a lot better if I would practice more than I do but I don't. I'm easily sidetracked. When I'm away and come home I've got all this catching up to do with other things so I don't get to practice as much as I need to.

MR: Do you have other hobbies or interests besides music?

EM: Just a little woodwork and doing things around the house and all like that. I love to make things with wood you know. But you need a house and a workshop and stuff and I don't have all that.

MR: Does your faith have anything to do with your music.

EM: Oh yes, oh yes. I feel honestly, I feel I'm always very thankful and I just try to send that out as much as I possibly can. Because for me to have two dollars in my pocket and the desire to give away fifty cents of it to somebody, for doing something for me or whatever, I mean I feel that that's what we're here for. We're all related. You might not like me but I'm still related to you. And I think we're all here to help one another, to make life easier for each other. I mean if you have that kind of attitude, to me it seems

like it's easier to smile — you know, somebody steps on your toe "oh, did I hurt you?" You know than to fight with them or something.

MR: Yeah, I agree. It takes more energy to be nasty.

EM: Yeah. And you can live a lot longer if you see the glass if half full, it's much better I think.

MR: Let me put this on here, if I can make it work.

EM: Wonderful people in this band. David Glasser played with Basie's band for a while, alto player, just wonderful. Larry Ham is not as well known as everybody else but he's an incredible sensitive piano player. He's got a lot of technique. He's a wonderful person to work with. The vocalist is absolutely the top of the line. Her father was Luis Russell, who worked with Louis Armstrong's band.

MR: Oh yeah. Luis Russell.

EM: This is Luis Russell's daughter. And her mother's name is Carline Ray, the wonderful bassist singer. She's got a lot of talent.

MR: When you do recording like this, how long in the studio—

EM: Well this is live.

MR: Oh this is a live thing.

EM: This is live. Two nights of recording two sets a night, and they tried to pick out whatever came out. But I think if we were in the studio it would have turned out a lot better for me anyway. I would have gotten a much better sound you know. And I think the next one will be in the studio.

MR: It seems like bass players are kind of usually in search for that perfect sound.

EM: Yeah, oh man, we're all crazy. I don't know whether it's the vibration — we complain more than anybody I know, except maybe reed players, they're always ahhh. They buy a box of a hundred reeds you know, and they only use three or two. Do you play?

MR: Yes. I'm a saxophone player.

EM: Oh if I'd known that I wouldn't have said that.

MR: No but it's funny they do that. But I'm not one of those people.

EM: No? Oh that's great.

MR: I don't know. I don't agonize over — Phil Woods told a great story about how he was complaining about his horn and couldn't get it man. And Charlie Parker came in to the club and played his horn and blew him away, and he says, "Well I'm not going to complain about my horn anymore."

EM: I used to go around with Oscar Pettiford, every place he went he would always — if he didn't have a lady with him — he would always say, "Come on let's go hang." And we'd go in the after hour joints during the day and in the evening you know and play. And I'd sit and watch him play and all like that. And the worst basses in the world. You know you

go in an after hour joint and you know, they don't have good basses there. Or you go into a club, some obscure club you know, and he would just wink at me. He'd go like this. I'm going to show him. But he was teasing me you know. And he'd make this guy's bass sound just like, like it was a Stradivarius or something. I remember once, I don't want to hold you, but once I went into an after hours joint and he told me that Art Tatum was going to be there. So I had to wait around for that. Art came in and he sat down at this piano, they put a mug of beer on top of the thing. It was an upright, an old upright. And he like sat down and he went like this, he had his hands over the keys and sat down and played, just incredibly. And I found out later that there were forty keys missing on the piano. So that's what Oscar does, you know? So you can't—

MR: You've got to negotiate with the instrument.

EM: Right, exactly. It's amazing how some people they sound. Look at Charlie Parker, the same thing. He would pick up your old horn that you were having—just like you say, and make it sound like wonderful.

MR: Oscar is a name that is in one of my favorite stories because I'm a big Cannonball Adderley fan. And he apparently sat in with Oscar when he first came up here and how he got his whole career started I think.

EM: Oscar was always helping somebody. He introduced me to Quincy Jones. Quincy was a little kid, he was about eighteen years old, as thin as that. He introduced me. And all these wonderful people that he would introduce me to, before they became famous. He was always trying to help somebody and bring them along. That's what you've got to do.

MR: How old was he when he died, I can't quite recall.

EM: I don't remember now. I don't think — he was maybe in his 40s.

MR: Yeah. It's too bad.

EM: He wasn't old at all.

MR: He played some jazz cello too, didn't he?

EM: Yes he did. Because he was actually in Woody Herman's band and he drank a lot. And being an American Indian, they can't really hold their liquor. So they were playing softball, and he was drunk. And he ran to first base and fell down and broke his arm in a couple of places. So he had steel — those nuts and bolts that they put in. So it was a little painful for him to play the guitar, I mean the bass. So he wound up playing the cello.

MR: I didn't know that.

EM: Yeah.

MR: Another practical thing.

EM: Pardon me?

MR: Another practical reason for doing something, right?

EM: Right. So Billy and I were the house trio, Billy's trio was at this place called the Downbeat, which used to be on 54th Street. And Oscar was a regular. We got to play with everybody in that place you know. Bill Harris came in, he was one of the featured —J.J. Johnson you know. We were the house trio. So I'd sit behind Oscar when he was playing. And then at night after the end of the gig, he and I would go in all these after hour joints and hang out and play and stuff.

MR: Do you have copies of all the records you played on?

EM: No. My second wife called me yesterday and told me that, "You know there's about 40 CDs or 44 CDs of yours on the internet." I said well wonderful. So she just sent me copies. But I don't have the records. My youngest daughter is trying to compile everything that I've done, just for family reasons.

MR: Sure. That would jog your memory too I bet.

EM: It would.

MR: You know, I remember— That's fantastic. Well I've enjoyed talking to you immensely.

EM: Thank you.

MR: Is there anything that I should have asked you that maybe I haven't? That maybe you'd like to throw in here?

EM: I can't think of anything off hand. Now when I leave here, I'll go oh, darnit.

MR: Well we'll do Part Two. We've done that in the past—.

EM: Have you really?

MR: —with some people, yeah.

EM: Well I'll give you a call if I think there's something. I hope this turns out good because I'm usually not too good at this kind of thing.

MR: Yeah? Well I think it was fine. So thanks for your time. I really appreciate it.

EM: Thank you very, very much. It was a great pleasure to meet you. Maybe we'll get a chance to play some.

MR: That'd be great. I would look forward to that immensely.

EM: If we ever come up to your school, will you play with us?

MR: Yes, I will. I'll be nervous like you were with Coltrane though, okay?

EM: I'll bet you won't because we'll make you feel so comfortable. I'll bet you won't be nervous. I guarantee.

MR: Okay.